Jiechi, in discussions with Southeast Asian countries on the South China Sea, justified Beijing's unyielding attitude: 'China is a big country, and you are small countries, and that is a fact.'[41] The implication of what Saran and Yang are saying is clear: until India substantially closes the power gap, there is little prospect of a lasting rapprochement.

Can India close the gap? With difficulty. If comprehensive national power (a concept much in vogue over the past two decades) is equal to a combination of economic, military, and soft power, where do India and China come out? Assuming, as was suggested earlier, that the three elements of power are synergistically related and that they affect each other, then comprehensive national power is the mathematical product of economic, military, and soft power (economic power times military power times soft power). Since it is hard to multiply unlike things – for example, GDP times numbers of weapons times numbers of movies produced in a year – we can instead multiply the ratios between India and China. Assuming China's GDP is five times the size of India's, its military (say) 1.2 times the size of the Indian military (on the land border), and its soft power also 1.2 times the size of India's (based on the 'cultural influence' scores of the two countries in the Lowy Index 2019), then we can say that China's comprehensive national power is about seven times that of India (5 times 1.2 times 1.2, equals 7.2). China's economy is five times India's, but its comprehensive national power may be seven times India's. That may be the truer gap between the two countries. Is it any wonder that the Chinese patronize India and that Indians fear China?